The AI Agent Design Canvas

Design the person first. Then the agent that serves them.

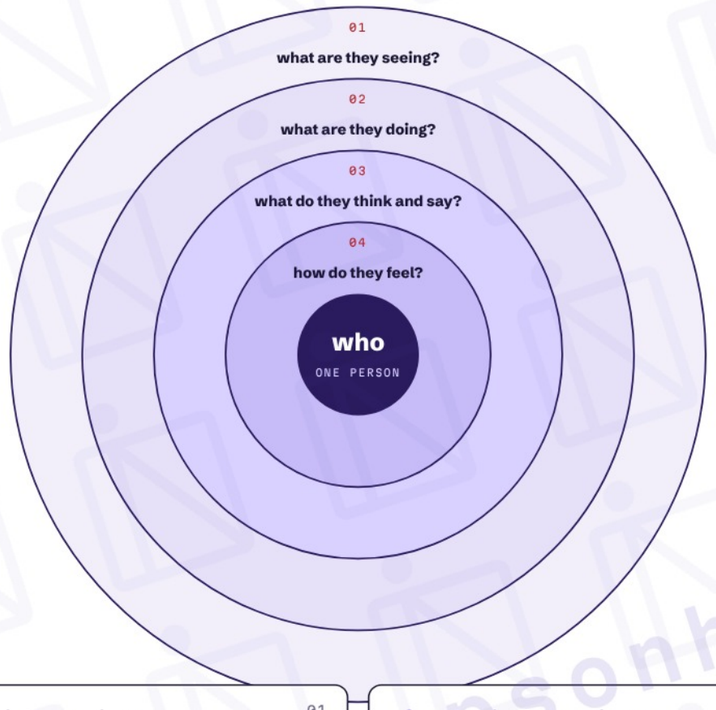
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who is our customer? A

- Who are we empathising with?
- What is their situation at the moment?
- What is their role in that situation?

what do they need to do? B

- What do they need to do?
- What tasks do they need to get done?
- What decisions do they need to make?
- How will they know they were successful?



personality and tone of voice 01

- What kind of personality would resonate most with this person — friendly, professional, humorous, calm?
- What tone of communication do they prefer: casual, formal, empathetic?
- Which human-like traits, if any, should the agent exhibit to make the user feel understood — and which would feel fake?
- Are there cultural or situational contexts that should change the tone?
- How can tone and personality build trust and rapport with this user?

core tasks 02

- What are the essential tasks the agent must perform to meet the person's key objectives?
- Which specific problems or frustrations from the left should the agent address first?
- How can the agent go beyond solving problems to delight the user?
- Are the tasks about providing information, facilitating decisions, or executing workflows?
- How should the agent adapt its handling to the user's journey and emotional state?

pains and frustrations C

- What are their fears, challenges and frustrations?
- What pain are they trying to move away from?

social experience 01

WHAT ARE THEY SEEING?

- What are they observing in their environment?
- What do they see others saying or doing?
- What are they watching or reading that might influence them?

physical experience 02

WHAT ARE THEY DOING?

- What are they doing today about their situation?
- What is their behaviour?
- Follow them in your mind and expand on what they do in a day.

specialisms 03

- What specific knowledge or expertise must the agent have to serve this person effectively?
- Are there niche domains where the agent must excel — financial advice, technical troubleshooting, a regulated field?
- Should it tailor responses to particular industries, demographics or cultural contexts?
- How can the agent demonstrate expertise to instil confidence?
- What must it refuse or hand to a human?

actions and APIs required 04

- What actions must the agent perform to meet user needs — retrieving data, initiating processes, making recommendations?
- What APIs or integrations are needed to facilitate these actions?
- Should it use third-party services — payment gateways, CRM tools — to complete tasks?
- What real-time data is required for accurate, timely responses?
- How should the agent handle failures or fallback scenarios when APIs are unavailable or actions cannot be completed?

wants and needs D

- What are their desires, wants and needs?
- What gain or benefit are they trying to move towards?

personal experience 03

WHAT DO THEY THINK AND SAY?

- What are some of the thoughts they are having?
- List a few quotes they might say, or have said, about their pains, gains or situation.

emotional experience 04

HOW DO THEY FEEL?

- How do they feel about the situation they are in?
- List some of the feelings they might be experiencing.

context the single situation this agent serves — moment, channel, constraint. One line, written after the left side and before the right.

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